A Life That Pleases God

A life that pleases God is not produced by rules or resolutions, but by the outworking of four God-given realities: our potential, our purity, our progress, and our purpose.

Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Four God-given realities

1 Thessalonians 4:1–12 · Outline I–IV

Potential · 4:1–2

- What is committed to us
- Received and repeated — practiced
- The commandments of the Lord Jesus

Purity · 4:3–8

- Sanctification is God’s will
- Abstain from sexual immorality
- A sin against Father, Son and Spirit

Progress · 4:9–10

- Taught by God to love
- Already loving all Macedonia
- “Increase more and more”

Purpose · 4:11–12

- A quiet life
- Mind your own business; work
- Walk properly before outsiders

The Christian life is not a set of prohibitions to be avoided. It is an outworking of a loving desire to please God. That’s it.

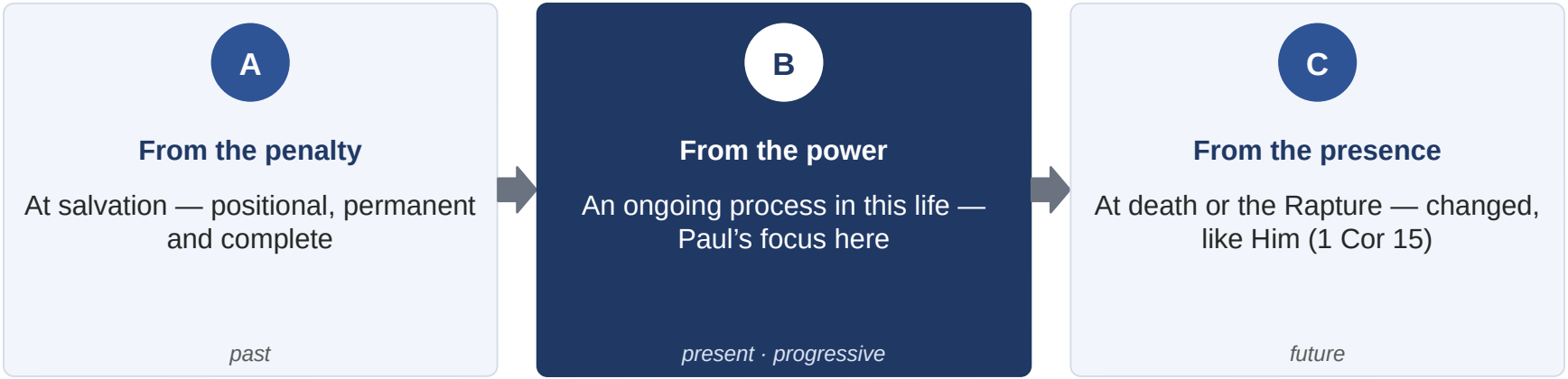
“We urge you … more and more”

1 Thessalonians 4:1–2 · I — Our potential

v.1	“Finally” — the hinge from doctrine to daily life	**Λοιπὸν** from now on — not “the end”
v.1	“We urge you” — not a command but earnest pleading	**παρακαλοῦμεν** we beg — same root as Paraclete
v.1	“Abound more and more” — the standard is overflow	**περισσεύητε** a river breaching its banks
v.1b	“Just as you received from us” — the old truths, repeated and practiced	**—** “Practice, man, practice”
v.2	“The commandments we gave you through the Lord Jesus”	**—** taught in a few months, c. AD 51

Three phases of sanctification

1 Thessalonians 4:3 · II.A.1 — The need for sanctification



ἁγιασμός — sanctification

- Set apart to God from the world
- Appears in vv.3, 4 and 7

πορνεία — sexual immorality

- All sexual sin outside marriage
- Then condoned — even in worship

A sin against the whole Godhead

1 Thessalonians 4:3–8 · II.A–C — Our purity

Against the Father · vv.3–5

σκεῦος vessel · the body

- God’s will: your sanctification
- Control your own body
- Not like the Gentiles who don’t know God

Against the Son · v.6

ὑπερβαίνειν to overstep

- Going beyond the boundary
- Defrauding a brother — πλεονεκτεῖν
- The Lord is the avenger — ἔκδικος

Against the Spirit · vv.7–8

ἁγιασμός called in holiness

- Not called to uncleanness
- Rejecting this is rejecting God
- Who has given us His Holy Spirit

When God says do this, or do not do this, He has already given us the ability to obey. We cannot say, “I can’t do it.”

In Adam or in Christ

1 Thessalonians 4:7 · II.C.1 — The rule

In Adam		In Christ
• Controlled by the Fall • Uncleanness — by natural birth • The natural man delights in vileness	vs	• Controlled by the Call • Holiness — by the new birth • The new man delights in virtue • The Spirit is in us (1 Cor 6:19–20)

John Phillips: “In Adam we are controlled by the fall; in Christ we are controlled by the call.” You are called by a holy God — therefore be holy.

Taught by God to love

1 Thessalonians 4:9–10 · III — Our progress



Love explained · v.9

θεοδίδακτοι taught by God

- φιλαδελφία — family love, planted at the new birth
- Taught by the cross and the Spirit

Love executed · v.10

- Toward all the brethren in all Macedonia
- Commended — not corrected
- “Increase more and more”

A quiet, working, watched life

1 Thessalonians 4:11–12 · IV — Our purpose

v.11a	Aspire to lead a quiet life — settled, not frantic	**ἡσυχάζειν** not silence but settledness
v.11b	Mind your own business	— MYOB — Paul used it first
v.11c	Work with your own hands — Jesus may come today; keep your job	— Paul's self-supporting model
v.12a	Walk properly toward those who are outside	— your walk commends the gospel
v.12b	That you may lack nothing	— plan ahead · work hard · live within your means

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 4:1–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul opens with parakalō (urge/beg) rather than a command. What does that tone of pleading tell us about the nature of the Christian life?

2. Paul says the Thessalonians are “taught by God” to love (theodidaktoi, v.9). How does God teach love — and what does that mean for what we expect of ourselves?

Apply

Live to Please God, Not the Crowd
Name one choice you make mainly to please someone else; ask what it looks like with God as the audience.

Love Is Taught by God — Then Practiced
Do one concrete, personal, unpublicized thing this week for someone you haven’t recently shown love to.

In one line: Please God — not by rules but by overflow: set apart to Him, loving more and more, living quietly and well before a watching world.